

Japan Chemicals: Asia investor visit feedback: High interest in electronic materials companies and individual catalysts amid volatility

We visited Asia (Hong Kong/Singapore) from the third to the fourth week of July, where we held meetings with c.55 investors over eight days. We summarize the key takeaways below. In the third week of July, in particular, stock market volatility was high amid concerns over the outlook for AI demand and the competitive landscape. Nevertheless, many investors remain positive on semiconductor and AI-related demand and fundamentals, and our impression was that interest remained high, particularly in electronic materials. Investor focus appeared to center on whether companies can make timely capex and exercise pricing power amid tightening supply/demand conditions for various AI-related materials. The stocks that generated the most discussion included Nitto Boseki (Nittobo), JX Advanced Metals, Mitsui Kinzoku, SUMCO, and Resonac (all of which we are Buy rated on).

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Nitto Boseki (Buy): Our impression through our discussions with investors was that many had been shorting or underweighting Nittobo shares over the past three months or so amid a deteriorating supply/demand balance for its mainstay product, T-glass, and relatively high valuations. The backdrop to this appeared to be a consensus negative bias among investors, who believe the company's competitive advantage could be eroded by new market entries and production increases by manufacturers in Taiwan, Japan, and mainland China in both low thermal expansion glass and low dielectric glass. On the other hand, there was strong interest in our recent upgrade (from Neutral to Buy). In particular, regarding T-glass, despite moves by new entrants, we got the impression there was some agreement with our view that the company's competitive advantage will remain for the time being, with the actual adoption of competitors' products being significantly delayed. An announcement of additional capacity expansion for T-glass (and price revisions), as well as the strength of earnings of NER glass cloth for PCBs in results could serve as catalysts, in our view.

Mitsui Kinzoku (Buy): Previously, our impression was that many investors held a positive view, but during our recent meetings, pessimistic views were generally more prevalent due to concerns over a decline in market share resulting from delays in capacity expansion for VSP™ and competitors' capacity expansions. However, in the view of the company and ourselves (link), we have the impression that these concerns are overdone and far removed from reality. Although many investors expressed pessimistic views on VSP, we were surprised that there was almost no discussion regarding MicroThin™, which forms the core of copper foil business profits, could achieve high profit growth, and is a product category where the

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company has a very high market share. We think this can be seen as evidence that investors have a pessimistic bias centered on VSP. Consequently, we believe the market is awaiting an announcement of a capacity expansion plan for VSP from the company to serve as a catalyst.

JX Advanced Metals (Buy): Our impression was that investor interest was focused on InP substrates. While the company has already announced a capacity expansion of c.10X, its pricing strategy remains largely unknown, and a few investors expressed concerns regarding capacity expansions by Chinese competitors. Therefore, if management provides explanations at future briefings regarding medium- to long-term earnings growth strategies, including long-term agreements, we believe investor expectations could rise for this business to become a second pillar alongside semiconductor sputtering targets, which are the profit driver of current focus businesses. We will be paying close attention to management's comments at the upcoming results briefing, as well as 1Q results, which we expect to be strong.

SUMCO (Buy): Compared to US investors, who generally held positive views, Asian investors' views were mixed (though this seemed to be heavily influenced by semiconductor sentiment at the time). The bearish view was that it will take time for wafer supply/demand conditions to tighten in the near term due to high inventory levels and the supply/demand gap resulting from past investments by various companies, making it difficult to implement substantial price hikes in long-term agreements (LTAs). We also noted a fair number of opinions that the stock does not look undervalued from a valuation perspective. On the other hand, we maintain a constructive stance based on our view that the 300 mm supply/demand balance will tighten considerably in 2027, driven by the broadening of AI demand and the impact of dual-wafer usage, and that we expect price increases from 2028 associated with LTAs.

Resonac (Buy): While we received a number of questions asking about the negative impact of glass cores on the company's earnings, we got the impression that almost no investors held concerns regarding the company's fundamentals. At the same time, there was a notable amount of feedback suggesting that the stock does not look undervalued based on consensus estimates. For FY12/27, we expect earnings to beat the consensus EPS estimate by slightly over 20%. We conveyed our view that a P/E of around 15X at that level suggests significant undervaluation, given that Resonac covers many of the key areas in AI semiconductor back-end processes and the potential of new packaging-related materials such as organic interposers, making it an attractive core holding in back-end materials.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Nitto Boseki

We are Buy rated on Nitto Boseki with a 12-month target price of ¥4,820. Our target price is based on the correlation between the materials sector's EV/GCI and the FY3/28E CROCI/WACC forecast (cash-return multiple of 0.7x plus a 60% premium to the sector average). Key risks include fluctuations in semiconductor demand, currency volatility, and changes in the competitive landscape for specialty glass.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - JX Advanced Metals Corp.

We are Buy rated on JX Advanced Metals with a 12-month target price of ¥5,010. Our target price is based on the materials sector EV/GCI and FY3/28E CROCI/WACC (CROCI multiple of 0.7X, plus the stock's recent historical premium of 25% to the sector

average).

Key risks: (1) Slowdown in semiconductor demand, (2) slowdown in AI server demand, (3) delays in structural reforms, (4) yen appreciation, and (5) fluctuations in copper and other metal prices.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Mitsui Kinzoku

We are Buy rated on Mitsui Kinzoku with a 12-month target price of ¥62,600. Our target price is based on the correlation between the materials sector's EV/GCI and our FY3/28E CROCI/WACC forecast (cash return multiple of 0.7X plus a 60% premium to the sector average). Key risks include slowdown in AI server demand, yen appreciation, and decline in prices for zinc and other metals.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - SUMCO

We are Buy-rated on SUMCO with a 12-month target price of ¥6,140. Our target price is based on the FY12/27-FY12/28 average correlation between the materials sector EV/GCI and CROCI/WACC estimate (using a cash return multiple of 0.7X).

Key risks: A slowdown in semiconductor demand, yen appreciation, and a greater-than-expected increase in depreciation and other fixed costs.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Resonac

We are Buy rated on Resonac with a 12-month target price of ¥23,920. Our target price is based on the correlation between the materials sector's EV/GCI and the FY12/27E CROCI/WACC (cash-return multiple of 0.7X plus a 30% premium to the sector average). Key risks include a slowdown in semiconductor demand, yen appreciation, and decline in graphite electrode earnings.

Disclosure Appendix

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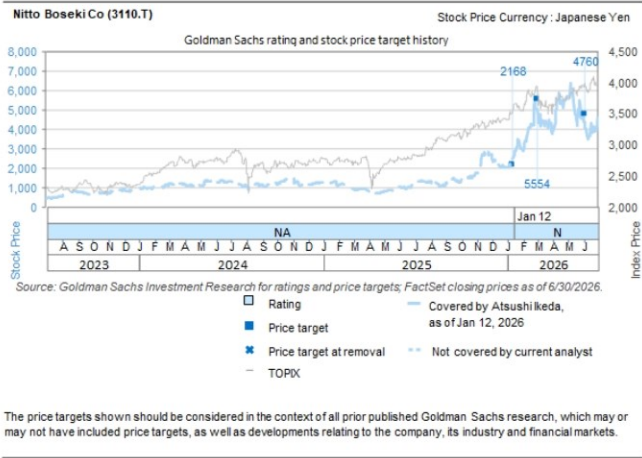
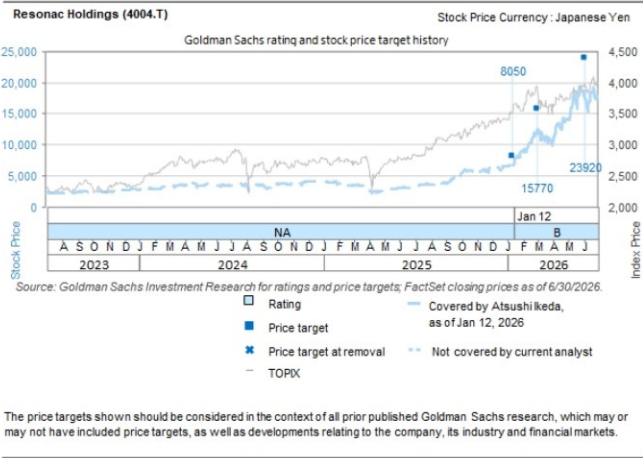
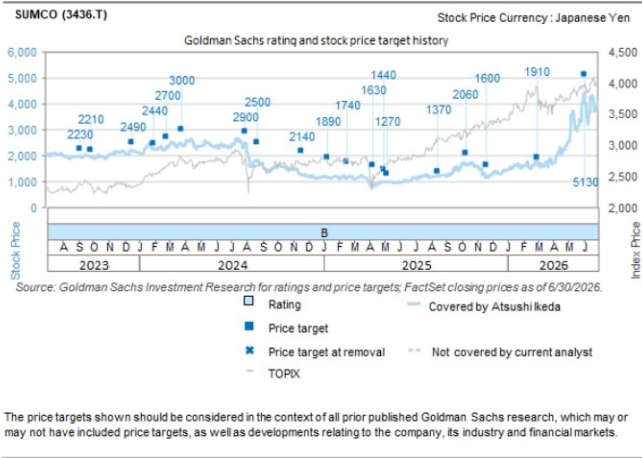
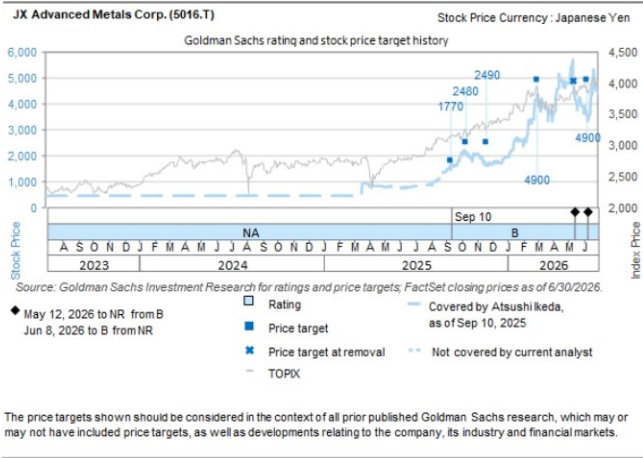
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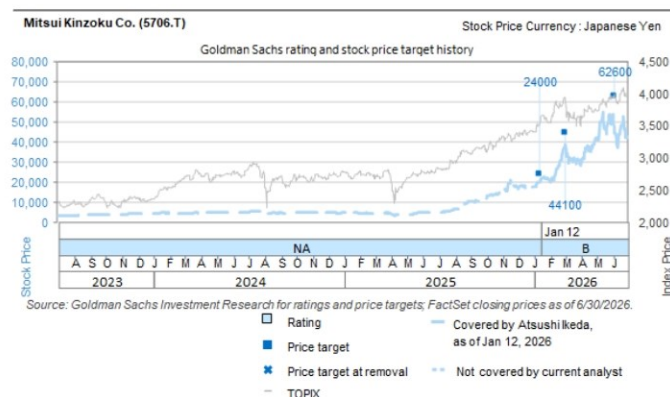
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Target price history table(s)

JX Advanced Metals Corp. (5016.T)

Date of report	Target price (¥)	Closing price (¥)
06-Jul-26	5,010	4,022
08-Jun-26	4,900	3,532
01-Mar-26	4,900	4,159
21-Nov-25	2,490	1,602
10-Oct-25	2,480	2,102
10-Sep-25	1,770	1,471

SUMCO (3436.T)

Date of report	Target price (¥)	Closing price (¥)
06-Jul-26	6,140	5,171
05-Jun-26	5,130	4,041
01-Mar-26	1,910	1,828
21-Nov-25	1,600	1,175
10-Oct-25	2,060	1,658
17-Aug-25	1,370	1,201
08-May-25	1,270	994
30-Apr-25	1,440	984
09-Apr-25	1,630	779
17-Feb-25	1,740	1,114
10-Jan-25	1,890	1,155
18-Nov-24	2,140	1,270
23-Aug-24	2,500	1,807
30-Jul-24	2,900	2,465
25-Mar-24	3,000	2,425
26-Feb-24	2,700	2,374
31-Jan-24	2,440	2,256
19-Dec-23	2,490	2,186
28-Sep-23	2,210	1,945
06-Sep-23	2,230	1,998

Resonac Holdings (4004.T)

Date of report	Target price (¥)	Closing price (¥)
05-Jun-26	23,920	17,315
01-Mar-26	15,770	11,930
12-Jan-26	8,050	6,810

Mitsui Kinzoku Co. (5706.T)

Date of report	Target price (¥)	Closing price (¥)
05-Jun-26	62,600	44,490
01-Mar-26	44,100	36,910
12-Jan-26	24,000	19,900

Nitto Boseki Co (3110.T)

Date of report	Target price (¥)	Closing price (¥)
06-Jul-26	4,820	3,515
05-Jun-26	23,800	4,050
01-Mar-26	27,770	5,040
12-Jan-26	10,840	2,508

Price targets shown in table(s) are unadjusted for corporate actions.

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